

AN IMPERFECT UNION

1860

When the South Carolina state convention voted unanimously on December 20, 1860, to secede from the Union, it was the culmination of a long process by which, in Abraham Lincoln's words, the nation had become a "house divided." Though victory in the Revolutionary War and the ratification of the U.S. Constitution had created a common sense of nationhood, many political differences had never been resolved. In particular, a growing number of Americans disagreed over the place of slavery in the nation's future and the Federal government's role in upholding it. While the Northern states had abolished slavery by this time, it continued in the South.

The period up to 1860 had seen great material changes for the nation and its people. The extent of the national territory multiplied with the Louisiana Purchase in 1803 and victory over Mexico in 1848. While most Americans still farmed or lived in small towns, new technology and mass immigration swelled the population and the national wealth. Southern cotton planters and Northern merchants prospered from cotton sales and the growth of factories, and from financial institutions that linked the interests of North and South.

Yet despite these links, by 1860, tensions ran high between North and South. Most white Americans remained indifferent or hostile to the aspirations of Black people, but many in the North feared that Southern domination of the Federal government could lead to the spread of slavery as new states entered the Union. Southerners saw critiques of enslavement as deeply threatening and a denial of the nation's historic acceptance of slaves as property.

Since the 1820 Missouri Compromise, a series of political deals had kept disunion at bay, but the election in 1860 of a president seen as hostile by many in the South brought matters to a head.

